NUTRITION

Reducing sodium in familiar meals

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Patient education. Follow your healthcare team’s advice.

Where does sodium come from?

Sodium comes from salt, packaged foods, sauces, seasonings, and prepared meals. Reducing it can help manage blood pressure. Ask your doctor or nutrition counselor whether you need a daily limit, especially if you have heart failure, kidney disease, or another condition. [1,2]

Check the foods you use often

Start with products that appear in your meals most days. Read the sodium amount and serving size on the label. Compare similar products on the same basis. A small serving listed on a package may be less than the amount you use. Keep photographs or packaging for questions at your nutrition visit. Start with the information most relevant to your care plan. [1,4]

Include sauces in the count

When discussing a meal, mention soy sauce, fish sauce, broth mixes, and other seasonings as well as the main ingredients. Their contribution can be easy to overlook. Ask how to adjust a familiar recipe without making the meal unacceptable to your household. Measuring what you add can make the discussion clearer than saying you use only a little. Your counselor can help identify an appropriate change.

Build flavor in other ways

Herbs, spices, garlic, and citrus can add flavor while you reduce reliance on salt. When suitable, use fresh ingredients and choose lower-sodium versions of packaged products. Rinsing certain canned foods may also help. Make changes gradually if that helps your household adjust. Ask before using a salt substitute, because some contain potassium and may be unsuitable with certain conditions or medicines. [1,3]

Plan a useful shopping change

Choose one product to compare on your next trip rather than trying to replace everything. Look at the cost, serving size, sodium, and whether you will actually use the alternative. A product with less sodium is not automatically a complete healthy meal. Consider it within your overall food plan. If lower-sodium products are hard to find, ask about preparation changes using available ingredients.

Ask questions when eating away from home

If possible, ask for sauces or dressings separately and find out how a dish is prepared. Explain your needs politely without assuming the cook can provide exact nutrient figures. Choose a practical option and follow your doctor’s guidance. If meals outside the home are frequent because of work or travel, discuss that pattern with your counselor instead of planning only for ideal home cooking.

Keep the change realistic

Bring a familiar recipe or food record to your next nutrition visit. Ask which sodium source to reduce first and choose an affordable change. Keep taking prescribed heart and blood pressure medicines; food changes support your treatment.

References

1. American Heart Association. (n.d.). How to reduce sodium. https://www.heart.org/en/healthy-living/healthy-eating/eat-smart/sodium/how-to-reduce-sodium

2. American Heart Association. (n.d.). Shaking the salt habit. https://www.heart.org/en/health-topics/high-blood-pressure/changes-you-can-make-to-manage-high-blood-pressure/shaking-the-salt-habit-to-lower-high-blood-pressure

3. MedlinePlus. (n.d.). Low-salt diet. https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000109.htm

4. MedlinePlus. (n.d.). Cooking without salt. https://medlineplus.gov/ency/patientinstructions/000760.htm

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